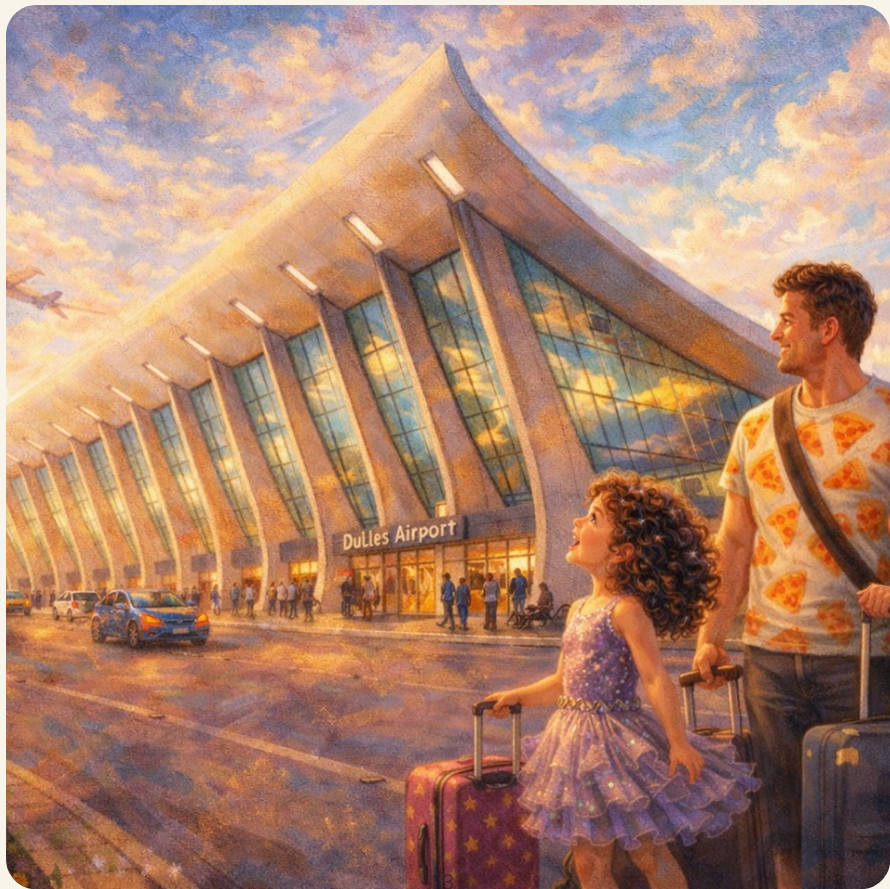




Dulles to New Mexico



In Reston, Virginia, the morning felt like a cozy hurry. Suitcases lined up by the door like sleepy robots waiting for instructions. Dan walked through the house with a checklist, tapping each item like a captain preparing a ship. Laura zipped the last suitcase with a triumphant zzzip! that sounded like the start of an adventure. Chelsea watched from the hallway, hugging her Adventure Notebook to her chest—the one she used on every trip. Inside it, she drew maps, collected tiny “badges,” and wrote down the best parts so she could remember them later. She was excited... and also a little nervous in a way that made her toes wiggle. “Today is a big day,” Laura said softly, and Chelsea nodded like she agreed with every word.



Chelsea opened her notebook and drew a map with the seriousness of a real explorer. She wrote RESTON! on the right side and then dragged her pencil far to the left until she found room for NEW MEXICO! “How far is that?” she asked, squinting at her own drawing. Dan held his hands apart like he was measuring the biggest sandwich in the universe. “About sixteen hundred miles by plane,” he said. Chelsea blinked. “That’s... a lot of sky.” Laura smiled and said, “Which is why we’re bringing snacks.”



In the car, the neighborhood slipped past the windows like a friendly goodbye parade. Chelsea saw trees, sidewalks, and familiar corners that suddenly felt extra special. Papa Puleo pointed out a lake sparkling in the morning light and said, “Reston was designed as a ‘new town’—a place where people could live, work, and play.” Mamma Karen added, “It started in the 1960s, and it was meant to feel like a community, not just buildings.” Papa Puleo grinned and said, “And the name is a joke you can remember: R.E.S. plus ‘ton’—like a whole ton of planning!” Chelsea giggled and imagined a giant ton of LEGO bricks labeled PLANNING. She waved out the window anyway, just in case Reston could wave back.



When they reached Washington Dulles International Airport, Chelsea's eyes widened so much they almost became circles. The main building rose ahead like a bold sculpture—long, low, and dramatic, with a roof that swept upward as if it were about to take flight. Dan said the architect designed it to feel modern and confident, like the future had a front door. Laura pointed to the slanted concrete columns outside, spaced like tall “tree trunks” holding up the roof. “See how the roof tilts?” she said. “It’s like a giant wing stretching and lifting.” Chelsea stared through the glass and noticed how the building felt open and bright, as if it wanted everyone to look outward toward the sky.



Inside the terminal, everything echoed in a soft, important way. Suitcases rolled across the floor like tiny thunder. Voices drifted up to the high ceiling, and announcements floated through the air like calm robot poetry. Chelsea stared at the slanted columns and the big glass walls and thought it felt like a cathedral for airplanes. The ceiling seemed to lean forward, guiding everyone toward the gates like an arrow made of light. Papa Puleo leaned close and said, “This airport opened in the early 1960s—people thought it looked like the future.” Mamma Karen nodded. “And it still does,” she said. Chelsea clutched her notebook and wrote: FUTURE PLACE—then drew a tiny empty badge box next to it, ready for later.



Chelsea expected a long walk to the plane, maybe with lots of boring hallways. Instead, an airport worker pointed them toward a big white vehicle with huge wheels. It looked like a bus that had decided it wanted to be a spaceship. “Is that... how we get to the plane?” Chelsea asked, half shocked and half delighted. Papa Puleo chuckled. “That’s one of Dulles’s famous mobile lounges,” he said, sounding proud like he’d invented it. Laura raised an eyebrow. “It’s basically a bus that thinks it’s an airplane,” she teased. Chelsea smiled and whispered, “Moon-buggy.”



They climbed aboard the moon-buggy bus, and the doors closed with a confident thunk. Chelsea pressed her hands to the cool window and watched the terminal slide away. The bus rumbled across the open airport area where airplanes sat like enormous resting birds. Then something unexpected happened—the moon-buggy lowered itself like it was kneeling. “It’s bowing!” Chelsea announced. Dan laughed. “It’s docking,” he said, “like it’s helping people step on safely.” Chelsea decided this vehicle had manners and deserved a thank-you.



As the moon-buggy rolled forward again, Chelsea's imagination snapped on like a flashlight. In her mind, the airport pavement turned into the surface of the moon—smooth, gray, and sprinkled with sparkles. The planes became rockets, waiting for launch. Chelsea sat up straighter and spoke in a serious astronaut voice. “Mission control, this is Captain Chelsea. We are approaching the rocket ship.” Laura covered her smile with her hand like she was trying not to laugh too loudly. Papa Puleo played along: “Copy that, Captain. Keep snacks secured from zero-gravity pretzels.” Chelsea nodded like this was the most important job on Earth—or on the moon.



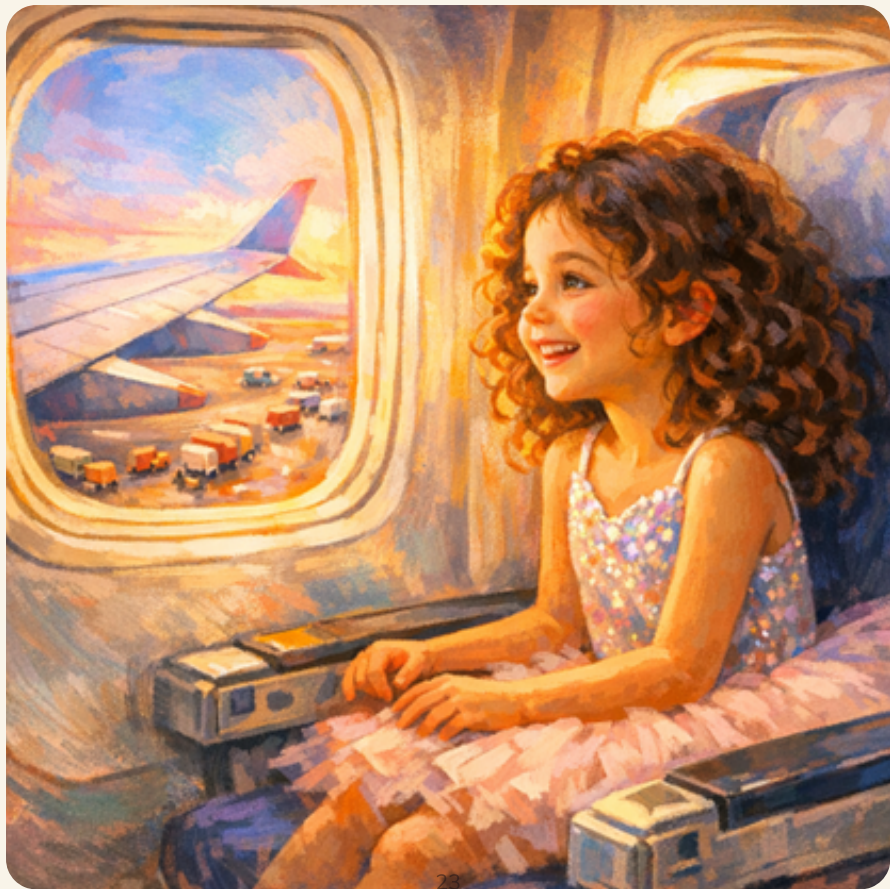
Because they arrived early, Dan said, “Want to do a mini-adventure inside the airport?” Chelsea’s answer was immediate: “Yes!” Laura called it a Terminal Treasure Hunt, and Papa Puleo declared, “We seek the legendary Numbers!” Mamma Karen leaned in like a spy and whispered, “Your mission is to find a 6 and a 7 before we board.” Chelsea straightened her shoulders. “Captain Chelsea accepts,” she said, and tucked her notebook under her arm like a secret agent clipboard. The airport suddenly felt like a maze full of clues.



They marched past shops and signs, scanning everything like detectives. Chelsea spotted a giant sign that said “Gates 6–12” and gasped like she’d found treasure. “Six!” she announced, pointing so hard her whole arm became an arrow. Papa Puleo squinted and said, “Is that a 6 or a fancy pretzel?” Chelsea frowned. “Papa. Pretzels don’t have straight lines.” Laura laughed and said, “Unless they’re airport pretzels—those can be anything.” Chelsea wrote in her notebook: 6 = FOUND.



Now they needed a 7, and that one was trickier. Chelsea looked at seat rows, posters, and even the shapes in the floor tiles. She found a line of chairs labeled Row 7, but Papa Puleo pretended to block the view like a dramatic villain. “Ah-ha! The Number Seven is protected by... the Seat-Row Dragon!” he growled in a silly voice. Mamma Karen made tiny claw hands and whispered, “Rawr... only brave travelers may pass.” Chelsea giggled, stepped around them, and tapped the label with one finger. “Seven,” she said proudly—then wrote in her notebook: CASE CLOSED. Dan gave her a quiet high-five, like they were spies who couldn’t make a scene.



With 6 and 7 safely found, Chelsea closed her notebook like a detective finishing a case. “Mission complete,” she whispered, and Papa Puleo responded, “Excellent work, Captain.” They followed the signs back toward their gate, and Chelsea noticed how the airport had its own rhythm—steps, rolling wheels, and voices bouncing gently off the tall walls. Near a huge window, they paused to watch airplanes taxi like they were lining up for a race. One jet rolled forward, engines roaring, and the sound thumped in Chelsea’s chest. It sped down the runway and lifted into the sky like it was suddenly lighter than air, and Chelsea’s mouth opened in a silent “whoa.” Mamma Karen said, “That’s the sound of an adventure getting started.”

They walked toward their gate, and Chelsea noticed how the airport seemed to have its own rhythm—steps, rolling wheels, soft announcements, and excited voices. Laura handed Chelsea a snack and said, “Fuel for explorers.” Papa Puleo adjusted his bag and pretended to march like a soldier. “We approach the gate with confidence!” he declared. Chelsea giggled and marched too, trying to match his serious face. Dan said, “You’d make a great travel teammate.” Chelsea felt proud, like she’d earned a secret badge already.

Then they stepped onto the jet bridge—the long hallway that connects the airport to the plane. The walls hummed softly, and Chelsea felt like she was walking into a storybook door. “This is the part where we become sky people,” Chelsea whispered. Dan smiled. “Sky people who buckle their seatbelts,” he reminded. Laura pointed ahead. “Your window seat awaits,” she said dramatically. Chelsea clutched her notebook like a passport to adventure. Papa Puleo said, “Captain Chelsea, your ship is ready.”

Inside the airplane, everything felt snug and busy. Chelsea found her seat and nearly cheered. “Window seat!” she announced, sliding in like she owned the sky. Laura helped her buckle up and said, “Click means safe.” Dan pointed to the wing outside. “That’s going to carry us,” he said. Chelsea pressed her forehead near the window and watched people and vehicles move below like tiny toys. Mamma Karen sat nearby with a calm smile that made Chelsea feel steadier.

The plane made a few beeps, like it was waking up and stretching. The engines began to hum, low and steady at first, then louder like a giant fan. Chelsea's butterflies returned for a quick practice lap. Dan noticed and offered his hand. Chelsea took it—not because she was scared exactly, but because holding hands made the moment feel real. “Remember what Papa said,” Laura whispered. “Calm is a superpower.” Chelsea tried her favorite trick: in for four... out for four, like she was slowly blowing on hot cocoa. The butterflies didn't disappear, but they stopped bumping into the walls of her tummy.

The airplane started rolling, and Chelsea watched the ground slide past outside the window. The runway appeared—long, straight, and serious. The engines rose to a powerful roar, and Chelsea felt pressed gently back into her seat. “We’re doing it,” she whispered. Laura squeezed her shoulder and said, “We’re doing it.” Papa Puleo grinned like a kid, and Mamma Karen looked peaceful, like she trusted the sky. Chelsea decided she trusted it too—at least a little more than before.

Then the wheels left the ground, and the world dropped away in the smoothest surprise. Chelsea's stomach floated for a second, like it forgot where "down" was. She gasped—and then she laughed, because it felt amazing. Outside, buildings shrank into tiny blocks, and the airport looked like a model set on a table. Chelsea spotted the dramatic roof of Dulles, sweeping up like a wing waving goodbye. "Bye, Reston," she said quietly, even though Reston couldn't hear her. Dan said, "Hello, clouds," and Chelsea smiled at that.

Higher and higher, the plane climbed until the ground became a patchwork quilt of colors. Chelsea rested her notebook on her lap and drew a quick doodle of a plane wing cutting through the sky. She wrote one sentence underneath: I am a sky person now. Laura peeked and said, "That's going in the travel journal forever." Papa Puleo asked, "Captain Chelsea, what is our destination?" Chelsea answered proudly, "New Mexico!" Papa Puleo nodded and said, "And you're doing a wonderful job traveling." Chelsea felt the butterflies finally turn into something else: confidence.

Chelsea leaned back and listened to the gentle airplane sounds—the hum, the soft air vents, the quiet voices. The moon-buggy bus and the Terminal Treasure Hunt already felt like stories she'd want to tell later. Dan smiled and said, "Another flight in the books." Laura added, "And you handled it like a pro," and offered a snack like a tiny trophy. Papa Puleo whispered, "Badge-worthy," and tapped Chelsea's notebook like it was official. Mamma Karen said, "Now let your body rest—adventures need energy." Chelsea watched the bright clouds for a moment longer... and then her eyes got heavy. She drifted to sleep, already dreaming of Albuquerque, New Mexico, where new adventures were waiting like the next page turning.



The End

